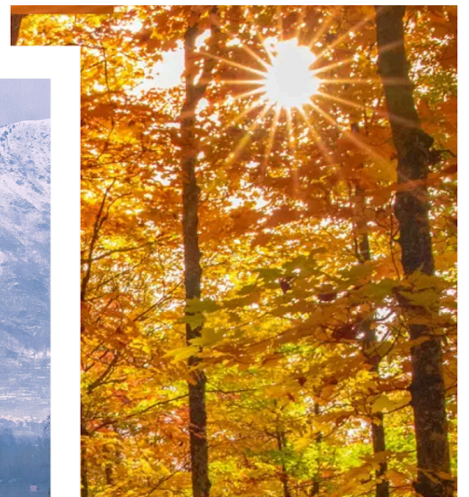


General Knowledge

Indian Geography

STUDY NOTES

Wildlife Conservation Efforts and Endangered Species



Wildlife Conservation Efforts and Endangered Species

To ensure the sustainable conservation of wildlife and their habitats, the Government of India has implemented several **special schemes**. Notable among these are **Project Tiger** (1973) and **Project Elephant** (1992). In addition, initiatives like the **Crocodile Breeding Project**, **Project Hangul**, and programs for the conservation of the **Himalayan Musk Deer** have also been launched to protect these species.

Project Tiger

- The Government of India has taken a pioneering initiative for conserving its national animal, the **tiger**, by launching **Project Tiger** in 1973.
- The **tiger reserves** are based on a **core/buffer strategy**, where the **core areas** are designated as **national parks or sanctuaries**, while the **buffer areas** are managed as **multiple-use zones** of forest and non-forest land.
- **Project Tiger** focuses on an **exclusive tiger agenda** in the core areas of tiger reserves, coupled with an **inclusive people-oriented agenda** in the buffer zones.
- It is an ongoing **Centrally Sponsored Scheme** under the **Ministry of Environment, Forests, and Climate Change**, providing **central assistance** to tiger States for conservation efforts.
- The **National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA)**, a **statutory body** under the Ministry, has a **supervisory and coordination role**, as outlined in the **Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972**.





Project Elephant

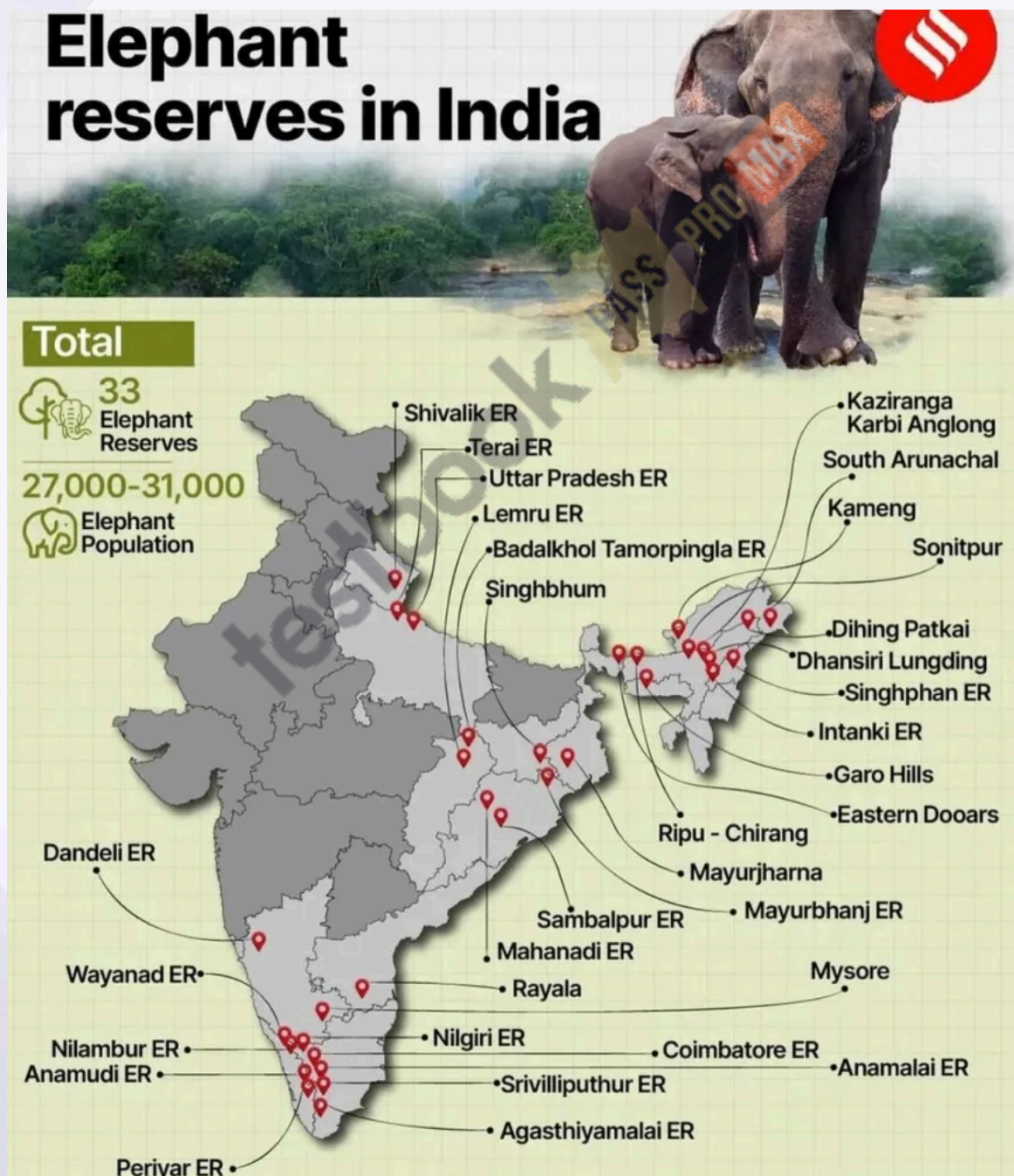
- **Project Elephant** is a **Centrally Sponsored Scheme** launched in **February 1992** to support the protection and management of elephants in states with **free-ranging elephant populations**.
- The scheme ensures the preservation of **elephant corridors** and **habitats** to secure the survival of wild elephant populations.
- In **2010**, the Government of India declared **elephants as a national heritage animal** based on the recommendations of the **National Board for Wildlife's Standing Committee**.

- Additionally, a proposed **National Elephant Conservation Authority (NECA)**, modeled after the **NTCA**, aims to strengthen conservation efforts by amending the **Wildlife (Protection) Act, of 1972**.

Recent Updates on Elephant Population (2024):

- **Tamil Nadu:** Population increased to **3,063** (up from **2,971** in 2023), with the **Sathyamangalam Forest Division** recording the highest number (**372**), followed by **Coimbatore Forest Division (336)**.
- **Odisha:** Population rose to **2,098** (up from **1,976** in 2017).
- **Kerala:** Population estimated at **1,793**, reflecting a **7% decline** compared to the previous year, alongside a significant reduction in **juvenile elephants**.

Elephant reserves in India



Reintroducing Cheetahs

Reintroducing cheetahs



- **8** African cheetahs
3 males and **5** females
will arrive this week!
- India had declared cheetahs extinct in **1952**

Sept 16
HOSEA KUTAKO
INTERNATIONAL
AIRPORT,
NAMIBIA

Boeing 747
"Jumbo Jet"
(Modified)
→
JAIPUR

Helicopter
→
KUNO NATIONAL
PARK,
MADHYA PRADESH

Sept 17

- **Scientific Name:** *Acinonyx jubatus*
- **Habitat:** Cheetahs inhabit a variety of landscapes, including **savannas, grasslands, and semi-arid regions** across **Africa**. Historically, they also roamed parts of **Asia** and **India**.
- **Extinction in India:** Cheetahs were declared **extinct** in **India** in **1952** due to **habitat loss** and **hunting**.
- **International Status (IUCN):** The **IUCN Red List** classifies cheetahs as **Vulnerable**, with their population declining due to **habitat fragmentation, human-wildlife conflict, and illegal trafficking**.
- **Current Range:** Most cheetahs are found in **sub-Saharan Africa**, particularly in **Namibia, Botswana, and parts of South Africa**. A small population of the critically endangered **Asiatic cheetah** survives in **Iran**.
- **Speed:** Cheetahs are the **fastest land animals**, capable of reaching **speeds up to 60-70 miles per hour (97-113 km/h)** in short bursts.
- **Recent Reintroduction in India:** In **2022**, India launched a **cheetah reintroduction project**, importing individuals from **Namibia** and **South Africa** into protected areas like **Kuno National Park** in **Madhya Pradesh**.

Few more wildlife conservation efforts:

Year	Conservation Effort	Species/ Animal	Key Focus & Details
2005	Indian Rhino Vision 2020 (IRV2020)	Greater One-Horned Rhino (Rhinoceros unicornis)	Goal: Achieve a population of 3,000 rhinos in seven protected areas in Assam. Key Areas: Kaziranga, Pobitora, Orang NP, Manas NP, Laokhowa, Burachapori, Dibru Saikhowa. Key Strategy: Wild-to-wild translocations to spread rhinos across parks.

1970s	Project Hangul	Kashmir Red Stag (<i>Cervus hanglu</i>)	Goal: Protect Hangul (Kashmir Red Stag) from extinction. Collaborators: Jammu & Kashmir government, IUCN, WWF. Key Focus: Habitat protection in Dachigam NP & Kishtwar forests.
1975	Crocodile Conservation Initiative	Crocodiles (Gharial, Mugger, Saltwater Crocodile)	Goal: Protect crocodiles from poaching and habitat loss. Key Species: Gharial, Mugger, Saltwater Crocodile. Key Areas: National Chambal Sanctuary, Katerniaghat. Techniques: Captive breeding, Rehabilitation, Release.
1981	The Manipur Brow-antlered Deer Project	Manipur Brow-antlered Deer (<i>Cervus eldi eldi</i>)	Goal: Conserve the Brow-antlered Deer in Manipur, Loktak Lake. Key Focus: Protecting the endangered species from habitat degradation & poaching. Key Areas: 35 km ² sanctuary.
1981	Project Himalayan Musk Deer	Musk Deer (<i>Moschus chrysogaster</i>)	Goal: Protect the Musk Deer from poaching and habitat loss. Key Focus: Captive breeding and habitat restoration in Kedarnath Sanctuary. Collaborators: IUCN, Govt. of India, Uttarakhand.
1976	Lesser Cats Project	Smaller Wild Cats (<i>Felis</i> species)	Goal: Protect four species of small cats in Sikkim and West Bengal. Species: <i>Felis bengalensis</i> , <i>Felis marmota</i> , <i>Felis lemruinki</i> , <i>Felis viverrine</i> .
1972	Gir Lion Sanctuary Project	Asiatic Lion (<i>Panthera leo persica</i>)	Goal: Protect the Asiatic Lion in Gir Forest, Gujarat. Key Focus: Conservation rules, habitat protection, prey species management, and anti-poaching.
1999	Sea Turtle Project	Olive Ridley Sea Turtle (<i>Lepidochelys olivacea</i>)	Goal: Protect the Olive Ridley Turtle along India's eastern coast (mainly Orissa). Key Focus: Nesting site protection, Satellite telemetry, Turtle Exclusion Devices (TED), public awareness.
2000s	Ganges Dolphin Conservation	Ganges River Dolphin (<i>Platanista gangetica</i>)	Goal: Conserve the Ganges River Dolphin (National Aquatic Animal). Key Threats: Pollution, entanglement, dam construction. Status: IUCN Red List - Endangered, CITES Appendix I. Key Areas: Ganges-Brahmaputra-Meghna river systems.
2013	Project Great Indian Bustard	Great Indian Bustard (<i>Ardeotis nigriceps</i>)	Goal: Conserve the critically endangered Great Indian Bustard (locally called Godawan) by protecting its habitat and remaining population. Key Areas: Rajasthan, Gujarat. Launched by: Honorable Chief Minister, 5th June 2013.

Status of Important Species in India

Common Name	Scientific Name	Location	IUCN Status	India Status
Bengal Tiger	<i>Panthera tigris tigris</i>	National parks across India (Sundarbans, Ranthambore, etc.)	Endangered	Endangered
Asian Elephant	<i>Elephas maximus</i>	North, Northeast, and Southern India (Assam, Kerala, Karnataka)	Endangered	Endangered
Indian One-horned Rhino	<i>Rhinoceros unicornis</i>	Assam, West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh	Vulnerable	Vulnerable
Ganges River Dolphin	<i>Platanista gangetica</i>	Ganges, Brahmaputra, and Meghna river systems	Endangered	Endangered
Snow Leopard	<i>Panthera uncia</i>	Himalayan regions (Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh)	Vulnerable	Endangered
Red Panda	<i>Ailurus fulgens</i>	Eastern Himalayas (Sikkim, Arunachal Pradesh, West Bengal)	Endangered	Endangered
Sarus Crane	<i>Antigone antigone</i>	Northern India (Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Assam)	Vulnerable	Vulnerable
Common Leopard	<i>Panthera pardus fusca</i>	Across India (Himalayas, Western Ghats, central forests)	Vulnerable	Least Concern
Great Indian Bustard	<i>Ardeotis nigriceps</i>	Rajasthan, Gujarat, Maharashtra, Karnataka	Critically Endangered	Critically Endangered
Himalayan Quail (Extinct)	<i>Ophrysia superciliosa</i>	Western Himalayas (Uttarakhand)	Critically Endangered (Possibly Extinct)	Extinct

House Sparrow	Passer domesticus	Across India (urban and rural areas)	Least Concern	Least Concern
Nilgiri Tahr	Nilgiritragus hylocrius	Western Ghats (Tamil Nadu, Kerala)	Endangered	Endangered
Gharial	Gavialis gangeticus	Northern Indian rivers (Ganges, Chambal)	Critically Endangered	Critically Endangered
Asiatic Lion	Panthera leo persica	Gir Forest, Gujarat	Endangered	Endangered
Black-necked Crane	Grus nigricollis	Ladakh, Arunachal Pradesh	Near Threatened	Vulnerable
Smooth-coated Otter	Lutrogale perspicillata	River systems across India	Vulnerable	Endangered
Golden Mahseer	Tor putitora	Himalayan rivers (Jammu & Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh)	Endangered	Endangered
Indian Pangolin	Manis crassicaudata	Across India (forests and plains)	Endangered	Endangered
Brow-antlered Deer	Rucervus eldii	Keibul Lamjao National Park, Manipur	Endangered	Endangered
Indian Cheetah (Extinct)	Acinonyx jubatus venaticus	Historically found in India (extinct since the 1940s)	Extinct	Extinct
Pink-headed Duck (Extinct)	Rhodonessa caryophyllacea	Historically found in India (Eastern wetlands)	Critically Endangered (Possibly Extinct)	Extinct
Sumatran Rhinoceros (Extinct)	Dicerorhinus sumatrensis	Historically found in Northeast India	Critically Endangered	Extinct